

How to Manage Fibromyalgia Flare-Ups Without Medication

Practical NHS-backed advice on how to manage fibromyalgia flare ups without medication.

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How to Manage Fibromyalgia Flare-Ups Without Medication

Quick Answer: Fibromyalgia flare-ups can be managed without medication using pacing, heat therapy, gentle movement, sleep hygiene improvements, and stress reduction techniques. NICE guidelines confirm these non-pharmacological approaches as effective first-line management for fibromyalgia.

Many people with fibromyalgia prefer to manage flares without or alongside minimal medication. NICE recommends non-pharmacological strategies as first-line treatment.

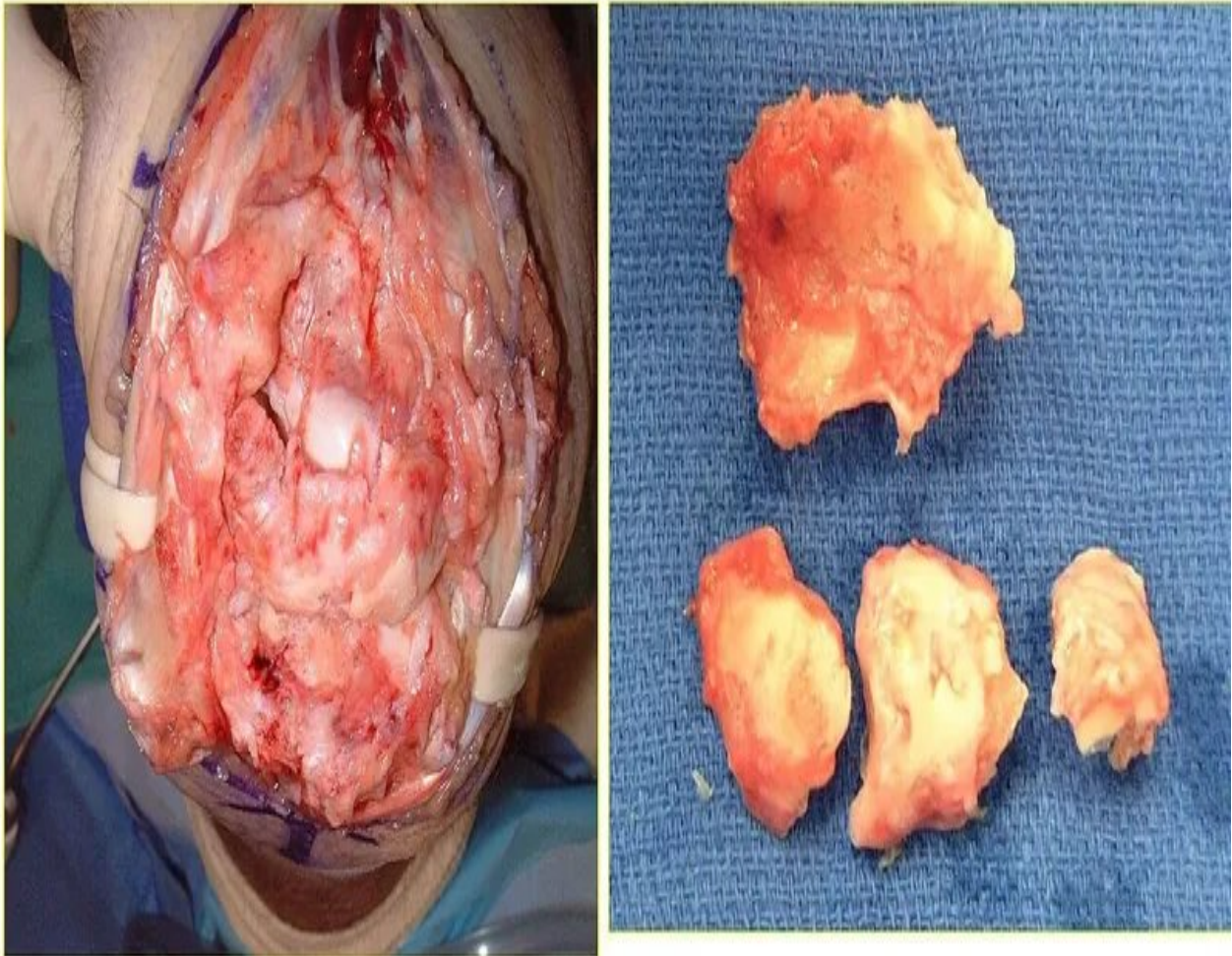
Pacing: Managing Energy During a Flare

Pacing is the most important tool for fibromyalgia flare management. Break activities into manageable chunks, plan rest breaks before exhaustion hits, and avoid the "push through" tendency that worsens post-exertional malaise. Aim to stay 70–80% within your "energy envelope."

Pacing Principles

- Plan activities in short bursts (10 minutes) with rest periods between
 - Avoid "boom and bust" — overactivity on good days followed by severe crash
 - Use a symptom diary to identify personal triggers
 - Set a sustainable baseline and build up very gradually
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Heat Therapy and Gentle Movement



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Warm baths, heat packs, and heated blankets reduce muscle tension and pain sensitivity. Gentle movement — a 5–10 minute walk or gentle stretching — maintains circulation and reduces pain sensitisation even during difficult periods.

Sleep and Stress Reduction

Poor sleep worsens fibromyalgia pain the following day. Improve sleep hygiene: consistent sleep/wake times, cool dark room, no screens for 60 minutes before bed. Breathing exercises (4-7-8 breathing), mindfulness meditation, and progressive muscle relaxation calm the nervous system and reduce central sensitisation.

Q&A;



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Question: How long does a fibromyalgia flare last? **Short answer:** Flares vary from a few days to several weeks. Identifying and removing triggers (overexertion, stress, poor sleep) and applying pacing and heat consistently shortens most flares.

Question: Can I exercise during a flare? **Short answer:** Very gently, yes. A short walk or gentle stretching is better than complete bed rest. Aggressive exercise during a flare will worsen symptoms.

Question: Does CBT help fibromyalgia flares? **Short answer:** Yes — pain-CBT has good evidence for reducing fibromyalgia severity. Ask your GP about referral to a pain management programme that includes CBT.